

Eating Well During Cancer Treatment

Quick Tips – Care Guide



After a cancer diagnosis, it's common to feel less confident about nutrition. Many survivors second-guess past food choices or start strictly avoiding “bad” foods like sugar and caffeine.

Because food can feel like one of the few things you can control, some diet changes may be truly helpful—while others may reflect a natural “bargaining” response (e.g., “If I’m strict enough, this will go away”). That’s understandable. But it’s worth grounding choices in what the science actually shows.

Eating for Cancer Prevention vs. Eating Well During Cancer Treatment

It’s easy to mix up eating for cancer prevention with eating well during cancer treatment—but the goals are different.

Cancer prevention focuses on limiting long-term exposure to potential dietary carcinogens (for example, meats cooked at very high temperatures or preserved with nitrates). During treatment, however, some of these foods may be useful if they help you eat enough and maintain weight.

During treatment, prioritize foods that:

- Taste good and are easy to eat
- Don’t trigger heartburn or nausea
- Support regular bowel movements
- Help you meet calorie, protein, and fluid needs

Typical treatment may include surgery, radiation, chemotherapy, and targeted therapies (including immunotherapy). Nutrition needs can shift with each:

Surgery: Protein needs increase to support healing. Many people benefit from ~20 extra grams/day—about 3 oz fish/chicken/lean meat/shellfish, or ~1 cup (8 oz) beans, tofu, or cooked quinoa.

Radiation: Avoid high-dose, single antioxidant supplements (e.g., vitamin C, beta-carotene, vitamin E) unless your oncology team recommends them, since they may interfere with treatment.

Chemotherapy: Hydration is critical, and protein needs often rise. If food intake is low, a ready-to-drink amino acid or peptide supplement can help with both fluids and protein.

Targeted therapy & immunotherapy: Some fruits (including grapefruit, noni, and mangosteen) can affect how certain medications are metabolized. ***Always check with your doctor or pharmacist to confirm what to avoid for your specific regimen.***

Common treatment side effects—and nutrition strategies that can help

Fatigue is common during all types of cancer treatment. **Dehydration can make it worse**, so make fluids a daily priority:

- **Morning:** start with extra fluids when you wake up.
- **Daytime:** sip water and other **unsweetened** beverages regularly.
- **Evening (after ~6 p.m.):** “**eat your water**” with hydrating foods (fruit, yogurt, smoothies, soups).
- **Soups and broths** are an easy way to add flavorful, electrolyte-rich fluids (see recipe sidebar).
- **Electrolyte options** like coconut water can also help.
- Some people find **green tea or a small amount of dark chocolate** helps with energy.

Appetite and taste changes (including early fullness) can make eating tough. Try:

- If food tastes **bitter or metallic**, switch to **non-metal utensils** (bamboo or plastic).
- Lean on **umami (savory)** flavors, which are often better tolerated than sweet or sour (broths, miso, soy-based dishes, mushrooms).
- Experiment with **temperature and texture** (smoothies, purees, crunchy foods, chilled foods) to find what goes down easiest.
- For **nausea**, ask your doctor about anti-nausea medications. **Ginger** is also a helpful option (ginger tea, ginger ale, ginger candies, or ginger baked goods).

Changes in bowel habits (constipation or diarrhea) are also common.

- **For constipation:**
 - Try gentle “natural laxative” foods like **prunes/plums, apricots, and cherries**.
 - **Purified aloe vera juice** may help some people.
 - Avoid **binding foods** if constipation is the problem (BRAT: bananas, rice, applesauce, toast).
- **For diarrhea:**
 - **BRAT foods can help** reduce symptoms. Other binding options include **fortified cereals** and dry breads/crackers (pita chips, melba toast).
 - Large amounts of **simple sugars**—including **lactose in milk**—may worsen diarrhea and gas. Consider **yogurt or fermented foods** instead.

For overall digestive comfort:

- Choose **small, frequent meals/snacks** instead of one or two large meals to support appetite and gut function.

Resources

[National LMS Foundation: Nutrition and Activity](#)

[Johns Hopkins Cancer Center](#)

[American Cancer Society](#)



Disclaimer: The content is provided for general informational purposes only and is not intended as, nor should it be considered a substitute for, professional medical advice. Do not use the information on this website for diagnosing or treating any medical or health condition. If you have or suspect you have a medical problem, promptly contact your professional healthcare provider.



Sarcoma & LMS Pathways

Care Guide - Quick Tips for Patients & Families

Trusted guidance for navigating diagnosis, treatment, and leiomyosarcoma

www.NLMSF.org